SPRING 2024: ANTH 123

Technologies of Enchantment

TUESDAY/THURSDAY, 3–4:15 PM; 113 BRAKER HALL

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Overview

This course is an intensive workshop in anthropological theory, focused on a particular kind of technology—what the anthropologist Alfred Gell called *technologies of enchantment*. Unlike stereotypical technologies that work on physical matter, technologies of enchantment are designed with *psychological* goals. These technologies are complex, and they are much older than they seem. Under Gell's umbrella, we can include not only contemporary "tech" like social media algorithms or generative AI, but also apparently simple objects like mousetraps or imposing entryway doors.

The course surveys a broad range of such technologies, as well as anthropological approaches to studying them. What distinguishes the anthropological approach from others you might encounter in other courses is an abiding interest in locating these technologies in social and cultural contexts: that is, technologies of enchantment are made by people in particular social positions, under particular interpretive frameworks for making sense of the world. We will also be relentlessly comparative, making sense of these technologies by bringing together diverse examples to explore their similarities and differences. "Technology" will take on a very broad meaning in this class, referring not only to physical artifacts, but also to a way of analyzing works of art, advertising, plans, scams, and magic tricks.

We'll begin with an extended foray into the anthropology of traps and trapping, where humans devise devices that work on the minds of animal prey; then, we will broaden our scope to think of other kinds of practices and objects as trap-like, before turning to a variety of literatures on some of the many ways humans try to entice, persuade, and trick each other.

Learning Objectives

The work in the course is designed to help you learn a few things:

1. To locate texts, facts, and artifacts in broader social and cultural contexts, thinking critically and generously about concepts, canons, and taken-for-granted categories.

2. To develop a command of a specialized area in the academic literature, following your own intellectual instincts.
3. To develop critical reading and writing skills, including the ability to analyze scholarly arguments and to make your own.

Assignments

This is the basic break-down of assignments, deadlines, and how much of your grade they count for, so you can see everything at a glance. More detailed descriptions and specifications for submission will be on the corresponding Canvas assignment pages, where you will also be submitting your work.

Assignment	Percentage	Deadline
Further reading	15%	various
Trap analysis	10%	2/23
Trap design	20%	3/12
Interface analysis	10%	4/19
Collection	20%	5/8
Attendance	25%	daily

Further reading (15%)

To encourage you to think of course readings as starting points rather than endpoints, there are three reading-related assignments that require you to explore texts beyond the syllabus:

- **Browse:** Pick a reading from the syllabus, go to its bibliography, and look through every source in it. (You should not read them, but you should look them up online in enough detail to find an abstract that you can read or text to skim.) *Output: A list of sources with one sentence each saying what you think its deal is, based on what you found. You may find it useful to try and roughly categorize them. Mark any number that you think you'd want to read next.*
- **Read:** Find an intriguing source referenced in one or more of the syllabus readings (probably from the **Browse** assignment, but not necessarily), and read it. Write up a précis that summarizes it, locates it within the literature, and describes where you might go from it: questions it raises, kinds of analysis it might support, methods it uses. (Your writing can be self-centered: you're not describing everything in it for anyone, but rather seeing what you find useful, what you might do with it, as though you're telling a

classmate.) *Output: a one-page (minimum) précis plus a short, informal presentation to the class.*

- **Brachiate**: This is the same as the previous assignment, except for where you find the reading. Pick a text referenced in the piece you read for **Read**, and read it. (You can also pick something that someone presented on in class, if it sounded interesting to you.) This will start to get more particular to your own interests and may not be explicitly about technologies/enchantment. *Output: one-page précis. No in-class presentation is required, though you may end up talking about your reading in small groups in class.*

You can complete the Further Reading assignments almost any time you want during the semester; I suggest that you distribute them each about a third of the way through. The only constraints: They can be turned in no later than the final day of class, and they cannot be turned in within a week of each other (so you'll need at least three weeks to complete them).

Reading encouragement program (up to 10%)

I expect that you will read all the texts assigned for a given day and come to class ready to discuss them. If it turns out that people are having trouble finding the motivation to read, I will implement a **reading encouragement program**. This will either require short reading responses to each assigned text or collaborative annotation of the texts using an online tool. Points will come from the attendance part of the grade, adjusted for how far into the term we are. (This is truly not intended to be punitive—it's just very important to the functioning of the class that you read!)

Trap Analysis (10%)

Following our day on operatory chains, you will choose a trap of some sort (broadly conceived) and analyze it, producing an operatory chain diagram and a short research memo about your trap.

Trap Design (20%)

Culminating our unit on traps, you will, in groups, design a trap of your own to catch some kind of prey. This can be as literal or metaphorical as you like (informed by class materials, of course), and it will be accompanied by a report analyzing it according to class themes. We will have some time in class to work on these together and to present them.

Interface Analysis (10%)

Following our day on the walkthrough method, you will choose a digital interface of some sort to analyze, examining the techniques it uses to influence and retain users.

Collection (20%)

Your final project in the class will be a digital "exhibit" of technologies of enchantment, curated by you around a theme of your choice. Each item in your collection will be accompanied by an explanatory blurb (like gallery wall text), and you will write up a curatorial statement (a short paper) about your theme and how the collection fits together.

Attendance (25%)

You know what this is. Details on the make-up policy are down below the course schedule.

Schedule

1. Thursday 1/18: Technology and Enchantment

Read during class:

- Gell, Alfred. 1988. "Technology and Magic." *Anthropology Today* 4 (2): 6–9. https://doi.org/10.2307/3033230.

2. Tuesday 1/23: Contraptions and the Mind

- Mason, Otis T. 1900. "Traps of the Amerinds—A Study in Psychology and Invention." *American Anthropologist* 2 (4): 657–675.
- Wadley, Lyn. 2010. "Were Snares and Traps Used in the Middle Stone Age and Does It Matter? A Review and a Case Study from Sibudu, South Africa." Journal of Human Evolution 58 (2): 179–92. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jhevol.2009.10.004. *(Only read the first two pages and the concluding remarks.*)
- Browse through the Pitt Rivers Museum collection of traps: http://tinyurl.com/pittriverstraps (This should take you to search results. If it doesn't, follow these steps: Navigate to the collection advanced search page; pick "Object" from the buttons at the top; put "trap" in the Description field; hit "search." Then you can check the box at the left of the results to show only results containing images—there should be about 260 of them.) Pick three traps that you find interesting for whatever reason and note their accession numbers, e.g., 1999.29.10.

3. Thursday 1/25: Style and Function

- Lemonnier, Pierre. 1993. “Introduction.” In *Technological Choices: Transformation in Material Cultures Since the Neolithic*, edited by Pierre Lemonnier. New York: Routledge, 1–35.
- Seaver, Nick. 2013. “The Lost Wanderers: Technology and the Auxiliary Motive.” *Medium*. https://medium.com/anthropology-and-algorithms/the-lost-wanderers-866b60a297ee.

4. Tuesday 1/30: Operatory Chains

- Coupaye, Ludovic. 2022. “Making ‘Technology’ Visible: Technical Activities and the *Chaîne Opératoire*.” In *The Palgrave Handbook of the Anthropology of Technology*, edited by Maja Hojer Bruun, Ayo Wahlberg, Rachel Douglas-Jones, Cathrine Hasse, Klaus Hoeyer, Dorthe Brogård Kristensen, and Brit Ross Winthereik, 37–60. Singapore: Springer Nature Singapore. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-981-16-7084-8_2.
- Choose an arbitrary technical process and sketch out an operatory chain diagram, following the examples in Coupaye’s text.

5. Thursday 2/1: Trap Theory

- Corsín Jiménez, Alberto, and Chloe Nahum-Claudel. 2019. “The Anthropology of Traps: Concrete Technologies and Theoretical Interfaces.” *Journal of Material Culture* 24 (4): 383–400. https://doi.org/10.1177/1359183518820368. *(This piece is the introduction to a collection of articles, many of which we‘ll be reading in this unit; it will refer to themes, theories, and thinkers that you haven‘t yet encountered, so take your time. Try to identify one or two ideas in here you find compelling enough to want to read more about.)*

6. Tuesday 2/6: Traps and Cultural Context

- Nahum-Claudel, Chloe. 2019. “From Mastery to Subjection: An Embodied Ethics of Entrapment in Amazonia.” *Journal of Material Culture* 24 (4): 473–490. https://doi.org/10.1177/1359183519828767.
- Swanson, Heather Anne. 2019. “The Entrapment of Trap Design: Materiality, Political Economy and the Shifting Worlds of Fixed Gear Fishing Equipment.” *Journal of Material Culture* 24 (4): 401–20. https://doi.org/10.1177/1359183519828769.

7. Thursday 2/8: Traps and Hospitality

- Swancutt, Katherine. 2012. "The Captive Guest: Spider Webs of Hospitality among the Nuosu of Southwest China." *Journal of the Royal Anthropological Institute* 18 (s1): S103–116. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9655.2012.01766.x.
- Kelly, Ann H. 2012. "The Experimental Hut: Hosting Vectors." *Journal of the Royal Anthropological Institute* 18 (s1): S145-S160. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9655.2012.01769.x.

8. Tuesday 2/13: Traps and Art

- Gell, Alfred. 1996. "Vogel's Net: Traps as Artworks and Artworks as Traps." *Journal of Material Culture* 1 (1): 15–38. https://doi.org/10.1177/135918359600100102.
- Halloy, A. 2015. "Pierre Smith's Mind Traps: The Origin and Ramifications of a Theory of Ritual Efficacy." *Anthropological Theory* 15 (3): 358–74. https://doi.org/10.1177/1463499615594559.

9. Thursday 2/15: Traps and Art 2

- Gell, Alfred. 1992. "The Technology of Enchantment and the Enchantment of Technology." In *Anthropology, Art and Aesthetics*, edited by Jeremy Coote and Anthony Shelton, 40–63. Oxford.
- Derlon, Brigitte, and Monique Jeudy-Ballini. 2010. "The Theory of Enchantment and the Enchantment of Theory: The Art of Alfred Gell." *Oceania* 80 (2): 129–42. https://doi.org/10.1002/j.1834-4461.2010.tb00076.x.

10. Tuesday 2/20: Traps and Computers

- Seaver, Nick. 2019. "Captivating Algorithms: Recommender Systems as Traps." *Journal of Material Culture* 24 (4): 421–36. https://doi.org/10.1177/1359183518820366.
- Miller, Daniel. 2000. "The Fame of Trinis: Websites as Traps." *Journal of Material Culture* 5 (1): 5–24. https://doi.org/10.1177/135918350000500101.

No class 2/22 (Tufts Monday)

Trap analysis assignment due 2/23

11. Tuesday 2/27: Gambling

- Schull, Natasha Dow. 2005. "Digital Gambling: The Coincidence of Desire and Design." *The Annals of the American Academy of Political and Social Science* 597: 65–81. https://doi.org/10.1177/0002716204270435.
- Second reading TBA

12. Thursday 2/29: Control Societies

- Deleuze, Gilles. 1992. "Postscript on the Societies of Control." *October* 59: 3–7.
- Cheney-Lippold, John. 2011. "A New Algorithmic Identity: Soft Biopolitics and the Modulation of Control." *Theory, Culture & Society* 28 (6): 164–81. https://doi.org/10.1177/0263276411424420.

13. Tuesday 3/5: The Trap

- Garrido Castellano, Carlos, and J. Griffith Rollefson. 2023. "Trapping Ecosystems: *Apeshit*'s Fugitive Politics of Post/Coloniality." *Journal of Popular Music Studies* 35 (1): 20–45. https://doi.org/10.1525/jpms.2023.35.1.20.
- Ziv, Tali. 2023. "The Trap: Care and Mystification in Carceral Governance." *Ethnos*, October, 1–26. https://doi.org/10.1080/00141844.2023.2264527.

No class 3/7 (I'll be traveling—work on your traps!)

14. Tuesday 3/12: Trap Presentations 1

15. Thursday 3/14: Trap Presentations 2

Spring Break

16. Tuesday 3/26 Magic

- Jones, Graham. 2011. "An Apprenticeship in Cunning." In *Trade of the Tricks: Inside the Magician's Craft*, 34–76. University of California Press. https://doi.org/10.1525/california/9780520270466.001.0001.

17. Thursday 3/28: Advertising

- Cochoy, F. 2007. "A Brief Theory of the 'Captation' of Publics: Understanding the Market with Little Red Riding Hood." *Theory, Culture & Society* 24 (7–8): 203–23.

https://doi.org/10.1177/0263276407084704.

- Second reading TBA

18. Tuesday 4/2: Persuasive Design

- Fogg, B. J., Gregory Cuellar, and David Danielson. 2009. "Motivating, Influencing, and Persuading Users: An Introduction to Captology." *Human Computer Interaction Fundamentals*, 109–22.
- Second reading TBA

No class April 4

19. Tuesday 4/9: Deceptive Patterns

These are three human-computer interaction papers that catalog types of "dark" or "deceptive" design patterns. You don't need to read all of them in detail, but you should focus specifically on how they categorize the different types of pattern.

- Gray, Colin M., Yubo Kou, Bryan Battles, Joseph Hoggatt, and Austin L. Toombs. 2018. "The Dark (Patterns) Side of UX Design." In *Proceedings of the 2018 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems*, 1–14. Montreal QC Canada: ACM. https://doi.org/10.1145/3173574.3174108.
- Mathur, Arunesh, Gunes Acar, Michael J. Friedman, Elena Lucherini, Jonathan Mayer, Marshini Chetty, and Arvind Narayanan. 2019. "Dark Patterns at Scale: Findings from a Crawl of 11K Shopping Websites." *Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction* 3 (CSCW): 1–32. https://doi.org/10.1145/3359183.
- Monge Roffarello, Alberto, Kai Lukoff, and Luigi De Russis. 2023. "Defining and Identifying Attention Capture Deceptive Designs in Digital Interfaces." In *Proceedings of the 2023 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems*, 1–19. Hamburg Germany: ACM. https://doi.org/10.1145/3544548.3580729.

20. Thursday 4/11: Walkthrough Method

- Readings TBA

21. Tuesday 4/16: Spam

- Brunton, Finn. 2019. "Spam." In *The SAGE Handbook of Web History*, edited by Niels Brügger and Ian Milligan, 564–76. London ; Thousand Oaks, California: SAGE Publications.

- Ziewitz, Malte. 2019. “Rethinking Gaming: The Ethical Work of Optimization in Web Search Engines.” *Social Studies of Science* 49 (5): 707–31. https://doi.org/10.1177/0306312719865607.

22. Thursday 4/18: Phishing

- McNealy, Jasmine E. 2022. “Platforms as Phish Farms: Deceptive Social Engineering at Scale.” *New Media & Society* 24 (7): 1677–94. https://doi.org/10.1177/14614448221099228.
- Dhamija, Rachna, J. D. Tygar, and Marti Hearst. 2006. “Why Phishing Works.” In *Proceedings of the SIGCHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems*, 581–90. Montréal, Québec, Canada: ACM. https://doi.org/10.1145/1124772.1124861.

Interface analysis due 4/19

23. Tuesday 4/23: Scams

- Burrell, Jenna. 2008. “Problematic Empowerment: West African Internet Scams as Strategic Misrepresentation.” *Information Technologies & International Development* 4 (4): 15–30.
- Yogarajah, Yathukulan. 2024. “‘Staging’ economic performances: Comparing startup and Multi-Level Marketing cryptocurrency projects.” Unpublished paper, under review. *(The author has kindly agreed to share this with us for the purposes of the class—please do not circulate beyond it.)*

24. Thursday 4/25: Collection Workshopping

- *On the last day of class, you’ll bring your work-in-progress collections, share them with each other in small groups, and workshop them.*

Grading

Specifications

Most assignments in this class will be graded pass/fail, according to whether you meet the requirements laid out in the assignment description. If you do not meet the requirements, you will usually have one chance to make a revision, following comments from me. This is called specifications grading, or “specs grading,” and I‘ve been using it across my classes

for the past few years with some success. The philosophy behind it is that grades reward you for completing the work, not for achieving excellence. The point of most of the assignments in this class is not to be great, but to practice—and practicing is easier and more effective without the burden of performance. Details about revision timelines and specifications can be found in the assignment descriptions. If you have any uncertainty about the specifications for an assignment, please let me know ASAP, so I can clarify.

You can think of the threshold for full credit as something like a B/B+ under typical grading, but as you'll see, the comparison to letter grades isn't always meaningful: Say you complete an assignment very well, but are missing one aspect of the specs—under a letter grade system, I might let it slide and just dock some points, but under specs grading you will have a 0 until you revise and fix the issue.

The exceptions to this policy are the two larger assignments: the trap design and the final collection. These will be given conventional letter grades, as they should demonstrate what you've already had a chance to practice during class.

Letter grades

I use conventional percentage-to-letter conversions for your final grade; you can see what letter grade you'll get in the class on Canvas (and it will already reflect any rounding up that may be applied). I do not automatically give A+ grades based on percentages; since the difference between A and A+ does not affect your GPA, I reserve the A+ for students who've earned the A and demonstrate exceptional effort and achievement in the class.

Policies

> ⚠ **Sorry**
> This is long and wordy. Read it all once; you may need to refer back to the attendance section in particular later on.

Conduct

I have a few ground rules for participation in this course:

- Treat each other with respect and patience.
- Avoid destructive critique of the readings.
- Participate actively. This course only works if you do.
- Communicate. Let me know when you're struggling or if something isn't working for you, as it happens.

Attendance

I do not like having attendance grades in my courses because I do not want to penalize students who have to miss class for any of the myriad reasons that can come up during the semester. However, this course has been designed around active collaboration during meeting times, and missing them means missing a substantial component of the class. I have experimented with eliminating attendance policies over the past few years, and I've learned that, for some students, extreme flexibility means that absences pile up until they have a hard time getting back into the class; this harms their work and deprives the rest of the class of their contributions. So, I'm trying a new policy for attendance this semester that tries to balance these concerns:

- **You can miss two course meetings, no explanation needed.** (Do not email me to explain yourself, feel bad about it, or whatever.)
- Beyond those two, **every other absence has to be made up with a supplementary assignment**, which is due within a week of your absence. There are no exceptions to this policy unless you arrange something with me *in advance*.
    - The extra assignments are duplicates of the "further reading" assignments **Read** and **Brachiate**. So, say you have a third absence: you could make it up by reading a source cited in one of the class readings and writing up a précis within a week.
    - The reason for the one-week deadline is that I want you to stay engaged with the course continuously during the term, even if you have to miss a meeting. If you have to miss class due to being very ill, getting back on top of things in one week may be hard. Let me know, and I can extend this deadline by a week, in certain conditions.
    - You can make up four absences in this way. At that point, you'll have missed about a sixth of our class meetings, and you should consider whether you actually are able to fully participate in the course. After four make-ups, further absences will affect your grade and cannot be made up.
    - This policy begins the very first day of class—so if you join late, you'll be using up permitted absences.

Accessibility

Your success in this class is important to me. If there are any circumstances (personal, health-related, family-related, etc.) that may affect your ability to participate, please let me know as soon as possible so that we can work together to make accommodations for you. The sooner I know about any issues, the better. Any such discussion will remain confidential.

You do not need to register with the StAAR Center or have a documented disability to request accommodations from me. However, you may find the support they offer useful, and I encourage you to see what they offer.

We remain in an ongoing pandemic. Following university expectations, this course is designed to meet in person; if conditions change, I may need to move some meetings online. Please check your email in the mornings before class just in case this ends up happening at the last minute.

Availability

I try to be a responsive emailer; you should expect a reply within 24–48 weekday hours of emailing me. (Please don‘t use the Canvas inbox thing to message me.) If you don‘t get a reply in that window, you should feel free to follow up with me as your message may have gotten buried in my inbox. I generally don‘t answer emails over the weekend or after 5pm.

I hold regular office hours to meet with students. Currently, these are held via Zoom, most days of the week. I use an online sign-up sheet to make sure that there‘s enough time for everyone who wants it and to spread you out through the hour. This time is reserved for you, and you should feel free to use it to talk to me about anything: the course, your academic program in general, or whatever you‘re interested in. You don‘t need to have a specific problem to sign up, and I enjoy talking with you outside the classroom, so feel free to make use of office hours as often as you like.

Late work

I am generally very flexible around deadlines, guided by a few principles: I do not want to make your life hard for no reason; I value my own time as well as yours; and extensions are not necessarily in your best interest. In general, if you get in touch with me *before* a deadline, we can work something out that balances your needs with mine and does not inadvertently make your life harder later on. I don‘t automatically deduct points for late work (though in some cases, especially for small assignments, I will simply not accept late work).

No matter what, if you find yourself in a situation that requires flexibility, you should let me know and we will work out something that works for both of us. (I am, as a rule, very accommodating, but extra flexibility is something for unexpected issues—not common inconveniences like having work in other classes.)

Academic Integrity

This course, like all your other courses, is predicated on the idea that it‘s you who‘s doing the work. If you don‘t do your own work, then you don‘t learn, and there‘s no point in your being enrolled in the class. Most academic integrity issues arise when students get

overburdened with work and panic—if you start to find yourself being overburdened, please talk with me so we can find better ways to manage things.

Plagiarism policies tend to focus on the less productive side of this issue, urging students to be “original” and telling them what not to do (buying papers, copying uncited text from other sources or using AI to generate text and passing it off as your own). Don‘t do any of that, of course, but I encourage you to take a more expansive view of what academic integrity means: Our expressions are not our own. Humans communicate with words and concepts—and within cultures and discourses—that are not of our own making. Communication is a matter of combining existing materials in meaningful ways. Different groups of people have different norms that govern these combinations: blues musicians, attorneys, programmers, poets, and physicists all abide by different sets of rules about what counts as “originality,” what kinds of copying and crediting are acceptable, and how one should relate to the materials from which one draws. In light of this, I do not use plagiarism (or AI) detection services like Turnitin (which, incidentally, make money by appropriating your work and encourage a hostile relationship between students and faculty). Rather than expending your energy worrying about originality, I suggest that you think instead about what kind of citational network you are locating yourself in. What thinkers are you thinking with? Where do they come from? How might their positions in the world inform their thoughts? What is your position relative to them? How might you re-shape your citational network to better reflect your priorities or ideals?

In this course, you‘ll continue to learn the norms of citation and attribution shared by the community of scholars in the social sciences. Failure to abide by these norms is considered plagiarism, as laid out in the Tufts Academic Integrity Policy, which you should familiarize yourself with. I am required to report suspected violations of this policy to the Dean of Student Affairs, and consequences can be severe. I will not spend much effort on detective work—you mostly harm yourself with this sort of thing—but if I catch it, you will find the limits of my flexibility.

The Syllabus Is a Living Document

This is a new course, and everything in the plan laid out in this syllabus is subject to revision. Any changes will be discussed in class, and I won‘t impose them unilaterally unless a serious issue emerges. Please let me know if you run into (or anticipate) any trouble with the plan here, so we can fix it. The current version of the syllabus will always be linked from our Canvas site.

This is version 1.0.